

Prospect-Source Checklist

Where to find your first 20 clients — concrete places to look, grouped by type.

A first-time freelancer's biggest early problem usually isn't skill — it's not knowing where to actually look for the first 20 people worth messaging. This checklist is a list of concrete places to look, grouped by type, with a note on how to approach each one. Work through 3–4 sources that fit your service before trying all of them at once.

"First 20" means 20 real candidates worth a first message — not 20 people who reply, and not 20 clients. Expect most of the 20 to go nowhere; that's normal, not a sign you picked the wrong sources.

A — Marketplaces & freelance platforms

Source	How to approach	What it's good for
Upwork / Fiverr, with a niche profile	Narrow your profile to one service ("AI FAQ setup for salons"), not "AI services." A specific profile gets fewer views and more replies from the right people.	Finding people already looking to pay for freelance help.
AI-tool directories and marketplaces	Some AI tools maintain a directory of certified implementers/partners. If you build on a specific tool, check whether it has one and whether you qualify to list yourself.	Warm leads who already trust the underlying tool.

B — Communities where business owners already talk

Source	How to approach	What it's good for
Local Facebook business groups ("[Your City] Small Business Owners")	Join, read for a week before posting anything. Reply helpfully to real questions first; only mention what you do if someone asks or it's directly relevant.	Local service businesses, often with low existing competition for your service.
r/smallbusiness, r/Entrepreneur, and niche subreddits for your target industry	Search before posting — look for people already describing the exact problem you solve, then reply to their post directly instead of writing a fresh pitch.	Finding people with an already-stated, specific problem.
Niche Slack/Discord communities for your target industry	Many trades and niches (e-commerce sellers, coaches, local service pros) have active paid or free communities. Search "[industry] Slack community" / "[industry] Discord."	Reaching a concentrated group of one business type at once.

C — Local & in-person

Source	How to approach	What it's good for
Local Chamber of Commerce or trade-association events	Attend as a guest if possible before joining. Business owners attend these specifically to be found — that intent is already in your favor.	Decision-makers who are reachable in person, not through a gatekeeper.
Co-working space bulletin boards / member Slack channels	Ask the space if you can post a one-line "I help X with Y" note, or just read what members already post about needing help with.	Early-stage founders and small teams, often fast decision-makers.
General local meetups (not just ones about AI)	Business owners attend general networking meetups too. Go to talk to people, not to pitch — let "what do you do" come up naturally.	Low-competition access to people who aren't being pitched constantly.

D — Your existing network

Source	How to approach	What it's good for
Former colleagues or managers now running or working at a small business	Ask how their business/team is doing before mentioning what you do. A genuine update conversation surfaces real problems you can offer to help with.	The warmest possible first message — they already know and trust you.
Family and friends who own or work at a small business	Ask for an introduction or a problem to look at, not a sale. "Do you know anyone who..." travels further than "would you like to buy..."	Referrals into businesses you'd never reach cold.
Anyone who already said "that sounds useful" when you described what you do	Keep a running note of every person who reacted positively, even in passing. Follow up with a specific example once you have one.	People who have already pre-qualified themselves as interested.

E — Visible-gap outbound (businesses you can just find)

Source	How to approach	What it's good for
Google Maps search for one business category in one area	Search "[business type] in [area]", then check each result's website. An outdated, missing, or template-only website is a visible, honest reason to reach out.	A large, filterable list of real, local, verifiable businesses.
Businesses with heavy repeat questions in their public reviews	Read recent reviews for phrases like "I wish they had told me..." or "had to call to ask..." — that's a documented, visible gap, not a guess.	A genuinely specific opening line, not a generic one.
Job ads for tasks AI could help with	Search job boards for listings like "data entry," "customer FAQ responses," or "social media posting" — a job ad is a business openly stating unmet need.	Businesses that have already budgeted for help with a related task.

F — Content & inbound (people come to you)

Source	How to approach	What it's good for
One real before/after example, posted publicly	Post one concrete example of work you've done (even for yourself or a friend), with a specific niche named. A vague "I do AI stuff" post gets no replies.	Attracting people who already see themselves in the example.
Answering real questions in community spaces, without pitching	Reply helpfully to specific questions in the communities from section B. Only mention what you do if it's directly on-topic or someone asks.	Building a visible, low-pressure reputation before you ever cold-message anyone.

None of these sources guarantees a reply or a client — they only put you in front of real, reachable businesses. Deciding which of them are actually worth a first message is a separate step, covered in the opportunity-qualification checklist included in this kit.